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The Ticket Doesn’t End the Argument

A Field Taxonomy of Paper, App, and No-System Deli-Counter Queues

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The problem

Delis and butcher counters facing queue-jumping complaints have adopted paper-ticket dispensers, app-based virtual queues, or left the line informal. Each intervention is sold as solving the queue. Little evidence tracks whether a formal system reduces disputes overall, or only relocates them.

Research questions

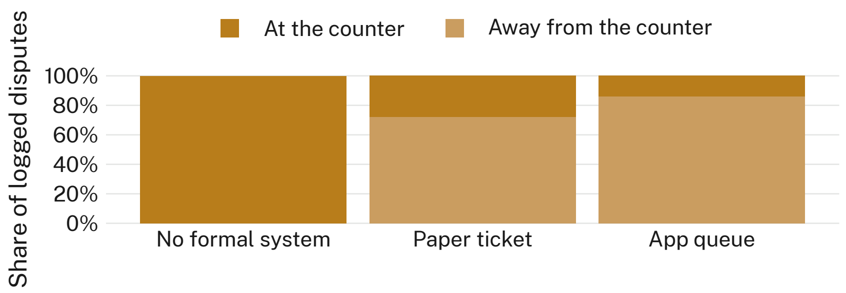
- Classify logged queue-jumping disputes by where they occur under each queueing regime
- Compare total dispute incidence across paper-ticket, app-queue, and no-system counters
- Test whether a formal system reduces disputes or relocates them

Study design

- 34 counters (11 paper-ticket · 12 app-queue · 11 no system) · 10 weeks · trained observers
- 8,400+ visits logged; 612 disputes coded by location and trigger
- Location codebook pre-registered; inter-coder agreement $\kappa = 0.81$

Findings

At-counter disputes fall sharply under both formal systems, but friction at the dispenser or in the app rises to compensate. Total dispute incidence is statistically indistinguishable across all three regimes.



Formal systems relocate disputes, not remove them: at-counter share falls to 28% under paper tickets and 14% under the app, the rest resurfacing at the dispenser or in-app (fieldwork, March-May 2026).

Implications

A queueing system relocates conflict rather than removing it, moving the argument out of the shopkeeper’s sightline without changing how often it happens. Next: extending the codebook to post-office and pharmacy counters.

Selected references

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We thank the participating delis and butchers for tolerating an observer with a clipboard.

Dispute counts de-identified at the counter level; no customer or staff names retained; location codebook lodged before fieldwork.

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“The ticket didn’t end the argument. It just moved it.”

Dispute rate: 3.7-3.9 per 100 visits, regardless of system (n = 34 counters).